

# Healthy Eating for Disease Prevention: Building a Sustainable Everyday Diet — Free Preview

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# Healthy Eating for Disease Prevention: Building a Sustainable Everyday Diet

## CHAPTER 1

### Learning Objectives

By the end of this interactive lesson, you will be able to:

1. Describe the core features of a disease-prevention eating pattern.
2. Use a simple plate method to build balanced meals.
3. Identify practical swaps that reduce sodium, added sugars, refined grains, processed meats, and unhealthy fats.
4. Adapt healthy eating principles to different cultures, budgets, schedules, and food access levels.
5. Create a realistic 7-day action plan for improving your everyday diet.

## CHAPTER 2

### Medical Safety Note

Healthy eating guidance is not one-size-fits-all. Before making major dietary changes, consult a qualified healthcare professional or registered dietitian if you have:

Kidney disease or fluid/electrolyte restrictions

Diabetes, especially if you use insulin or medications that can cause low blood sugar

Heart failure, high blood pressure requiring medication, or complex cardiovascular disease

Food allergies or intolerances

A current or past eating disorder

Pregnancy, breastfeeding, or fertility-related nutrition needs

Gastrointestinal disorders or medically prescribed diets

Religious, cultural, sensory, disability-related, or special dietary needs that require individualized planning

The strongest evidence supports a mostly plant-forward, minimally processed eating pattern rich in:

Vegetables

Fruits

Whole grains

Beans, lentils, peas, and other legumes

Nuts and seeds

Healthy unsaturated fats, such as olive oil, avocado, nuts, seeds, and fatty fish

It also means limiting:

Processed meats

Refined grains

Added sugars

Excess sodium

Saturated fats and trans fats

Highly processed foods that crowd out more nourishing choices

This does not mean everyone must eat the same foods or become vegetarian. A disease-prevention diet can be adapted to many

cuisines, budgets, religious practices, family traditions, cooking skills, schedules, and levels of food access.

### CHAPTER 3

## Quick Check

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Which statement best describes disease-prevention eating?

- A. “Eat one superfood every day.”
- B. “Avoid all carbohydrates.”
- C. “Build a consistent pattern of mostly minimally processed, nutrient-rich foods.”
- D. “Follow the strictest diet possible.”

Best answer: C.

Disease prevention is more strongly linked to long-term eating patterns than to one food, one nutrient, or short-term restriction.

Your daily eating pattern can influence long-term risk of:

Heart disease

Stroke

High blood pressure

Type 2 diabetes

Excess weight gain

Certain diet-related cancers, though evidence varies by cancer type and dietary factor

Premature mortality

Food affects health through multiple pathways, including blood

pressure, blood cholesterol, blood sugar regulation, inflammation, gut health, body weight, and nutrient status.

The goal is not perfection. The goal is to make your usual pattern protective more often than not.

## CHAPTER 4

### **QRU Translation™**

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Healthy eating for disease prevention is not about a miracle food, detox, or short-term diet. The best-supported approach looks similar to Mediterranean-style or DASH-style eating:

More vegetables, fruits, beans, lentils, whole grains, nuts, and seeds

More unsaturated fats instead of mostly saturated or trans fats

Less processed meat, added sugar, refined grain, excess sodium, and highly processed food

Moderate portions that support energy balance

A realistic plan you can repeat

The most sustainable version uses foods you can access, afford, enjoy, prepare, and maintain.

Use the acronym PLATE to remember the foundation of disease-prevention eating.

## CHAPTER 5

### **P — Plants first**

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Make vegetables, fruits, legumes, whole grains, nuts, and seeds the foundation.

## CHAPTER 6

### **L — Limit ultra-processed extras**

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Reduce foods high in added sugars, refined grains, sodium, processed meats, and unhealthy fats.

## CHAPTER 7

### **A — Add healthy fats and protein**

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Choose protein and fats that support heart and metabolic health, such as beans, lentils, fish, poultry, tofu, nuts, seeds, olive oil, and avocado.

## CHAPTER 8

### **T — Tune portions and sodium**

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Build meals that fit your energy needs and season foods with herbs, spices, citrus, vinegar, garlic, onion, and lower-sodium options.

## CHAPTER 9

### **E — Eat in a way you can sustain**

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Adapt the pattern to your culture, budget, schedule, cooking ability, family needs, and food access.

## CHAPTER 10

# Memory Sentence™

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Disease prevention comes from the pattern on your plate, not a miracle food.

A simple disease-prevention plate can look like this:

## CHAPTER 11

# ½ Plate: Vegetables and Fruits

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Choose a variety when possible.

Examples:

- Leafy greens
- Carrots
- Cabbage
- Tomatoes
- Peppers
- Broccoli
- Squash
- Berries
- Apples
- Oranges
- Mango
- Frozen mixed vegetables
- Canned fruit packed in juice or water

## CHAPTER 12

## **¼ Plate: Whole Grains or Starchy High-Fiber Foods**

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Examples:

Brown rice

Oats

Whole-grain bread

Corn tortillas

Quinoa

Barley

Whole-wheat pasta

Sweet potatoes

Potatoes with skin

Plantains, cassava, or yams in balanced portions

### **CHAPTER 13**

## **¼ Plate: Protein**

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Examples:

Beans

Lentils

Chickpeas

Tofu or tempeh

Fish

Skinless poultry

Eggs

Plain Greek yogurt

Lean meats in moderate portions

Nuts and seeds as additions

## CHAPTER 14

# Add: Healthy Fat and Flavor

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Examples:

Olive oil

Avocado

Nuts

Seeds

Tahini

Nut butters

Herbs and spices

Salsa

Vinegar

Lemon or lime juice

## CHAPTER 15

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